TEXORA · LECTURE SHEET

# Compliance and Certification: WRAP, SAI/SA8000, BSCI and the Certification Process

*The social-compliance systems that gate market access for Bangladeshi apparel — the logic of compliance, the WRAP principles, SA8000 under Social Accountability International, amfori BSCI, a comparison of the three, and how certification is earned, kept and lost.*

TE-4108 · QUALITY ASSURANCE AND MANAGEMENT IN TEXTILES · TOPIC 6 · LEVEL 4 TERM 1

## 1. Compliance: the concept

**Compliance** means operating in conformity with applicable requirements — national law first (in Bangladesh: the Labour Act and Rules, factory, fire and building-safety law, environmental law) and, on top of law, the codes of conduct of buyers and international standards. For an export garment factory, compliance is not philanthropy: it is a condition of orders. Buyers audit (Topic 5's second-party audits) because their own legal and reputational exposure travels down the supply chain. Two truths organise the topic: compliance has a floor (law — non-negotiable) and a market layer (codes and certifications — demanded by customers, sometimes exceeding law); and genuine compliance is a management system, not an audit-day performance — the systems below all test exactly that distinction.

## 2. WRAP — Worldwide Responsible Accredited Production

**WRAP** is an independent non-profit certification programme focused on the apparel, footwear and sewn-products sectors, certifying individual factories against 12 principles built on local law and international workplace standards:

| # | PRINCIPLE | # | PRINCIPLE |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Compliance with laws and workplace regulations | 7 | Freedom of association and collective bargaining |
| 2 | Prohibition of forced labour | 8 | Health and safety |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | Prohibition of child labour | 9 | Compensation and benefits |
| 4 | Prohibition of harassment or abuse | 10 | Hours of work |
| 5 | Non-discrimination | 11 | Environment |
| 6 | Customs compliance (incl. transshipment rules) | 12 | Security (supply-chain security criteria) |

WRAP certification is graded by audit performance and history — **Platinum** (two years), **Gold** (one year) and **Silver** (six months) — with audits by WRAP-accredited monitors including unannounced elements in the cycle, and certification requiring corrective action on findings.

## 3. SAI and SA8000

**Social Accountability International (SAI)** is the standard-setting organisation that owns **SA8000**, a certifiable social-accountability standard applicable across industries, built on ILO conventions and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. SA8000 has nine elements: (1) child labour, (2) forced or compulsory labour, (3) health and safety, (4) freedom of association and right to collective bargaining, (5) discrimination, (6) disciplinary practices, (7) working hours, (8) remuneration, and (9) a **management system** element — policies, worker representation (including a Social Performance Team), risk assessment, monitoring and corrective action. That ninth element is what distinguishes SA8000 from a checklist: the factory must run a system that keeps itself compliant between audits. Certification is by SAAS-accredited bodies, with surveillance audits across a three-year cycle.

## 4. amfori BSCI

**BSCI** (Business Social Compliance Initiative), run by amfori, is not a certification but a **social auditing and improvement system** used by its member companies (many European retailers) across their supply chains. Its Code of Conduct states 11 principles — including fair remuneration, decent working hours, no child labour, no forced labour, freedom of association, safe working conditions, environmental protection and ethical business behaviour. Audits grade producers (A “outstanding” through E “unacceptable”) with a validity period; results sit on the amfori platform visible to linked customers, who decide what grades their business requires. BSCI's philosophy is continuous improvement with shared audits — one audit serving many customers — instead of pass/fail certification.

| | WRAP | SA8000 | AMFORI BSCI |
|---|---|---|---|
| Owner / nature | WRAP non-profit; certification | SAI standard; certification via SAAS-accredited bodies | amfori; audit + improvement system, no certificate |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Sector | Apparel / sewn products focus | All industries | All consumer-goods supply chains |
| Core structure | 12 principles | 9 elements incl. management system | 11 Code principles, graded A–E |
| Validity signal | Platinum 2 y / Gold 1 y / Silver 6 mo | 3-year cycle with surveillance | Grade + audit validity on platform |
| Decision-maker | WRAP certification board | Certification body | Each customer sets its accepted grade |

## 5. The certification process

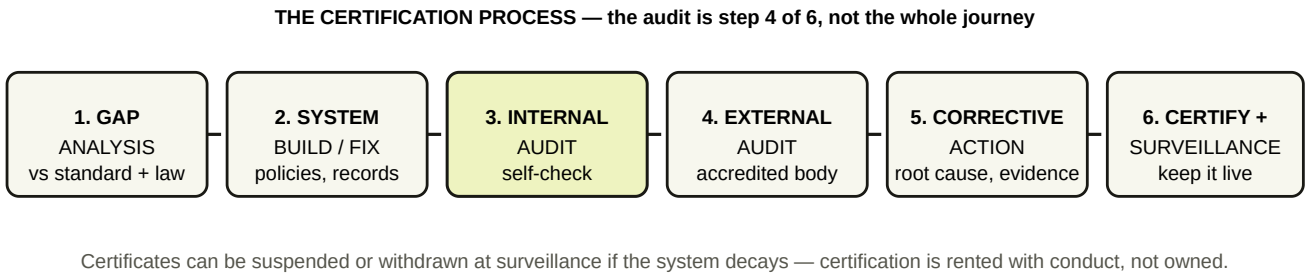



Fig. 1 — Certification process flow, common in structure to WRAP, SA8000 and ISO schemes.

Reading the flow against this course: steps 1–3 are the factory's own TQM machinery (audits of Topic 5, corrective action of Topic 2); step 4 tests it; step 5 is where most weak factories fail — corrective actions that repaint rather than repair; step 6 converts certification from an event into a maintained state. Factories that treat the certificate as the goal relapse between audits; factories that treat the system as the goal find audits nearly boring — which is the point.

## 6. Compliance in the Bangladeshi RMG context

Bangladesh's garment sector operates under this architecture daily: national law and BGMEA/BKMEA requirements as the floor; structural, fire and electrical safety under the post-2013 safety regimes (the Accord/Alliance legacy, now the RMG Sustainability Council); and buyer codes, WRAP/SA8000 certification or BSCI grading as market layers, often several at once for one factory. The quality engineer's role in compliance is the unglamorous core: honest records, calibrated safety and test equipment, functioning worker committees, corrective actions closed on evidence — in short, running the system on the 364 days when no auditor is present.

## Glossary

**Compliance** — conformity with law and applicable codes/standards. **WRAP** — sector certification against 12 principles; Platinum/Gold/Silver grades. **SAI / SA8000** — Social Accountability International and its certifiable 9-element social standard. **BSCI** — amfori's graded social audit system (A–E), not a certification. **Gap analysis** — structured comparison of current state against a standard's requirements. **Surveillance audit** — periodic follow-up audit that keeps a certification valid.

## Key points

• Compliance = law (floor) + buyer codes and standards (market layer); both are audited.
• WRAP: 12 principles, apparel focus, graded certification. SA8000: 9 elements with a management-system core, all industries. BSCI: 11 principles, A–E grading, improvement system rather than certificate.
• The certification process runs gap → build → internal audit → external audit → corrective action → certify + surveillance; step 5 decides whether it is real.
• In Bangladeshi RMG all three systems coexist with national law and safety regimes; the system must run on non-audit days.

## Practice

1. A European buyer asks a factory for "your BSCI certificate". Correct the request precisely.
2. A factory holds WRAP Gold but dismisses its worker-participation committee between audits. Name the principles/elements at risk in each of WRAP, SA8000 and BSCI.
3. Arrange into certification order and justify the position of the internal audit: external audit, gap analysis, corrective action, internal audit, certification decision, system building.
4. Why does SA8000's element 9 make it harder to "stage" compliance than a pure checklist audit?

### Answer key

1. BSCI issues no certificate: the factory can offer its latest amfori BSCI audit report and grade (A–E) from the amfori platform, with the audit's validity period, and evidence of corrective-action progress. The buyer's underlying need — assurance of social performance to its own standard — is met by the report and grade, and the factory should ask which grade the buyer requires.
2. WRAP: Principle 7 (freedom of association and collective bargaining) — and the credibility of Principle 1. SA8000: element 4 (freedom of association/collective bargaining) and element 9 (management system — worker representation is structural, so dissolving the committee is a system failure, not an isolated lapse). BSCI: the Code principle on freedom of association and collective bargaining, with grading consequences at the next audit. In all three, worker voice is a mechanism of the system, not a facility to be switched on for audits.

3. Order: gap analysis → system building → internal audit → external audit → corrective action → certification decision (then surveillance). The internal audit sits immediately before the external one because its purpose is to find and fix nonconformities on the factory's own terms — it is the rehearsal with consequences removed, and its findings feed the corrective-action step before an accredited body is involved.
4. Element 9 requires functioning internal machinery — policies, a Social Performance Team with worker representatives, risk assessment, internal monitoring and corrective-action records over time. Documents can be printed for an audit day, but a committee's minutes, risk assessments and closed corrective actions spanning months form a dated evidence trail that is far harder to fabricate consistently; auditors test it by triangulating records against confidential worker interviews. The system requirement converts compliance from a state performed for auditors into a process that leaves evidence continuously.

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